

Images of the Desert — Rotem and Acacia

PRIMARY TEXTS: ISAIAH 32, PSALM 1

To be a gift of the desert. To be shade—bringing just enough at just the right time.

Lessons or hastily quoted sayings such as these can seem cliché in the midst of our own desert wanderings. Thirsty and weak and not sure how we are able to carry on—we cry *When will this stop? I just need some peace... Some rest... Shade...*

**There are times
where we do
get lost, feel
separated.**

And then there are times where we look back on our desert moments, see the footprints in the rocky soil, and notice the others wandering its vast landscapes as well. We've talked about the beauty of the desert. The land of the shepherds where we can grow closer to God—hear His voice. But there are times where we do get lost, feel separated. We lose His voice in the cavernous depths of a wadi or it is drowned out by the roaring of a flash flood.

One of my most difficult desert moments was 12 years ago, wanting nothing more than to be a mother, and the journey to finally holding my son in my arms.

After setting my own plans aside and finding shade in the advice of others, we scheduled a meeting with a specialist. When you're at your wits' end in the desert, and at a loss of direction, wisdom, and even hope, you voice some of your most vulnerable thoughts. I'd been there for a while, and I was losing the little hope I'd been holding onto, going to this appointment, as the reality of the situation hit us before leaving to meet the doctor.

We couldn't begin to imagine how we could afford this appointment, let alone afford the answers it might give us. Moments before getting into the car, the phone rang, and we were told someone had gifted our church community a sum of money for the couple "struggling with infertility." The floodwaters began to recede. I could hear the echo of the shepherd's voice again. There was hope. There was shade, just in time, at the last possible moment.

After multiple medications and ultrasounds and shots, we reached the very last round of treatment we had funds for. Then, like an acacia tree at the deepest point in the desert, there was the image of my baby swimming on the ultrasound screen. We had graciously been gifted just enough—*just enough shade—just in time.*

**We had graciously
been given just enough**

Our collective definitions of “just in time” and “just enough” differ. It can be so painfully difficult to trust the Story. Not all deserts or stories conclude with the answers or endings we want. More current deserts feel barren and desolate. We reach out our right hand and can’t seem to grasp God quite yet. The shade of the rotem bush hasn’t appeared. And the acacia tree still seems to lie dormant, its season hasn’t yet come, and there’s absolutely no good answer we can conceive as to why. Yet, we can plant ourselves and each other in the Text and hold onto hope, waiting for the rains to come.

Desert moments remind us that this world is broken, and that we can partner in putting it back together. Stories of just enough and just in time can show us one way we can begin to mend the brokenness—to bring and be shade to those we see in the deserts. The ones behind us, before us. To not let them wander alone.

**We can begin
to mend the
brokenness**

When we begin to share our stories in community, including our deserts, something powerful happens. When we trust enough to be vulnerable and honest with those we meet. When we give to others, celebrate with others, mourn with others, or when we just live our lives looking for moments to share joy and grief, we learn we are capable and called to play a role in creating just enough shade, just in time.

We can absolutely trust the Story because, as the saying goes, “we know the Author,” but we also know there are other beautiful characters—people whom we are meant to walk with along the journey, providing shade for one another along the way.

PRAYER

*Our Father in Heaven,
Where there is wind, may we be shelter.
Where there are storms, may we provide refuge.
Where there is thirst in the desert,
may we become water and shade.
May we plant ourselves in streams of living water,
digging our roots into the wisdom of the Word,
so that when the season comes
we may flourish and prosper
as living images of what God calls us to be—
a gift of the desert,
a priest to the Kingdom,
a child of God.
Be for us, and may we be,
just enough, just in time,
to the broken deserts that surround us.*

Amen

THE FOUR PILLARS

EPISODE 27

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



TEXT

What might be important to meditate over from the images and texts of Isaiah 32 and Psalm 1? What part of these Texts challenge you to dig deeper, to grow roots like the acacia?



COMMUNITY

How does your community create a safe space to share desert moments? How might you provide shade for one another? Where could you seek community if you don't have it?



DISCIPLESHIP

Who can you bring alongside you to not only walk through their deserts with them, but share your desert moments as well? How can you help another see small moments of shade, and trust that those can be just enough? Who needs you to show them that they are not alone?



WRESTLING

What are you wrestling with? The new contextual images of what shade in the desert can look like? The patience attributed to the image of the acacia? Remember, questions and wrestling are good! Especially in community.



Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to bemabesorah@gmail.com.



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*We believe that **if we do our part in creating space for God, He will fill it.** What spiritual practices might you need to connect with God and learn to recognize His voice? To find His presence at the outstretched fingertips of your right hand? How might the smallest practice fill you with more of Him and get you from one source of shade to the next? What practice could you refine, pick up again, or challenge yourself to try for the very first time? If you create the space—He will fill it—and His presence will be just enough, at just the right time.*

CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

*We believe young adults are shaping the future, and they need to experience the shade of the Holy Spirit and hear the voice of the Shepherd through people like you. **They need to see what it looks like to follow God in the wilderness—even if shade isn't seen from our desert starting points!** Let God do the heavy lifting, trust He'll lead you on those righteous, rocky paths, and be on the lookout for those young people to help them navigate the desert themselves.*

SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*Imagine how our world, our theology of work, might be different if we lived each moment trusting that God will provide just what we need, just in time. Even if it appears different from our own interpretations. Or if we lived each moment looking to provide shade to those wandering in deserts nearby. Living in intimacy with God is about how you put Him on display, in how you pursue your 9–5, and how that changes you and the people you meet. Does your physical work put you in a position to be shade? A position to lead others to hear the voice of God? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can make an impact. **You are doing sacred work and can be that shade—no matter where you are.***